



Historic breakthrough: Saina announced her arrival on the senior circuit in 2006 with a title run at the Philippines Open, becoming the first Indian woman to lift a four-star tournament crown. K. MURALI KUMAR

more time to develop, but I think you should be playing at the elite level by the time you are 18. I played the Olympics by then. You should at least start seeing results by then and be competitive at the world level, even if you aren't winning all the matches.

How much of this do you think comes from the fact that these girls are all training separately? I've worked in multiple academies. I think about 70 per cent of a player's ability is innate and about 30 per cent is what a coach can do. Gopi (Pullela Gopichand) sir got me to an excellent level, but it got harder for him to coach me when there were

30–40 other players to look after. With Vimal (Kumar) sir at the Prakash Padukone academy, I think I improved my speed. I was always a very good rally player and a hard hitter, but with Vimal sir, my movements got faster.

But at the same time, the quality of any academy depends on the kind of players who train there. And both Gopi's academy and the Padukone academy were lucky because they had a lot of very good players. Now, with the National Centre in Guwahati, you will see good players coming from there in the future. I think the important thing is to ensure you have enough sparring partners. If that is the case, you don't need everyone to train in the same place.

What do you think is keeping us from producing another elite women's singles player?

I definitely think we have it in us to produce another very good women's singles player. I think one thing going for my generation is that our coaches were a lot stricter with us. This generation is a lot smarter than we were, but at the same time, I feel they are a lot softer than we were. It's not easy to scold them because they take things to heart a lot faster.

But for us, we took the coach's word as law. Whatever he or our parents said was right. We would follow it even if it hurt a little. We would push ourselves a little more because of that mentality. Obviously, if you hurt something, have a really bad day, or get seriously injured, then that is different. But if you can push yourself, then you need to do that.

What do you think is the difference between you at 18 and the current generation of Indian talent?

I think what probably separates me from a lot of the girls today is just my pain threshold. That's what determines how much you can train. I don't know if it doesn't exist now or if the players are just a lot more careful about their bodies, but I'm seeing a lot of injuries like shin

injuries, damaged ACLs and meniscus tears. These are not easy injuries either. I don't know whether I was just lucky or whether my body was stronger.

When you get pain in these areas, you have to wait and see how the injury develops over 2–3 months. So you take time to recover, and your ranking drops.

I think we have four really strong contenders under 20. But at the same time, I think we need to start seeing results at the senior level by next year. They will have enough experience by then. I was 17 or 18 when I won my first super series, so they need to start pushing for the same results now.

They have everything in place. They have good strokes and movement.

I think one of the reasons it's taking longer to make a mark is that the game has become more of a defensive rally game now. Apart from An Se-Young, I think the girls are a little slower. It's a lot of high lifts. That overall game isn't the same, so maybe they will take longer to develop the physical strength that will give them success in today's game.

Out of Anmol (Kharb), Unnati (Hooda), Tanvi (Sharma) and Anupama (Upadhyaya), who do you think has the right tools to make it to the next level?

I think right now the four girls, Anmol, Unnati, Tanvi and Anupama, are at the same level. If you put them in a tournament, each of them can beat the other on her day. So if you are looking at which one of them can go to the next level, I can't say. I think if you want to be competitive at the world level, you need to see one player who can beat every other domestic player and really separate themselves from that group. That's how it was with Sindhu and me as well. I'm not seeing that yet. Right now, I see all of them stuck at the same place. But at the same time, they are still regularly reaching the second and third rounds of international tournaments, which is a good sign.